

France and, by marrying King Charles VI's daughter, heir to the French throne. He dies before he can succeed to the French throne.

1415 Led initially by Joan of Arc, the French push the English out of France, recapturing Normandy in 1449, Gascony in 1450, and finally ending the war with the recapture of Aquitaine in 1453.

1419–67 Reign of Duke Philip the Good of Burgundy, who acquires further territory in the Netherlands. His successor, Charles the Bold (1467–77), unites his territories, but the French king Louis XI (1461–81) seizes French Burgundy while the rest becomes part of the Habsburg family lands.

1494 Charles VIII invades Italy, starting a long series of wars with the Habsburg emperors. In 1525 the capture of Francis I by Spanish troops at Pavia and his subsequent imprisonment in Spain brings the wars to a climax. Francis renounces French claims in Italy, notably Milan, but hostilities are renewed and are only settled at the Treaty of Cateau-Cambrésis in 1559.

1517 The Reformation starts in Europe. Many French people convert to Protestantism (known in France as Huguenotism).

1562–98 In the French Wars of Religion, Protestant Huguenot and Catholic nobles fight for supremacy following the death of the last Valois king, Henry II, in 1559.

1572 Four thousand Huguenots are killed on the orders of Catherine de Medici, the regent of France, in the St. Bartholomew's Day massacre.

1594 Henry IV, who has converted to Catholicism in 1593 on the grounds that "Paris is worth a mass," is crowned the first of the Bourbon kings. The Huguenots are granted freedom of worship in the 1598 Edict of Nantes.

1608 The foundation of Québec in Canada leads to the creation of a large French empire in North America.

1610 Henry IV is assassinated. He is succeeded by Louis XIII, whose first minister, Cardinal Richelieu, consolidates the monarchy's standing both at home and abroad.

1627–28 French Huguenots rise in revolt but are crushed at La Rochelle.

1628 During the 30 Years War (1618–48), France goes on the offensive against Spain and the Holy Roman Empire in Germany, with the intent of dismembering the powerful Habsburg empire. France defeats Spanish attacks and gains Roussillon from Spain in 1642. In 1640 the French support Portuguese and Catalan revolts against Spanish rule, and they aid the Neapolitan revolt in 1647.

1643 Louis XIV, the "Sun King," ascends the throne at the age of five. Cardinal Mazarin acts on his behalf as first minister.

1659 The foundation of Fort St. Louis on the Senegal River marks the start of France's colonial empire in West Africa.

1661 The young king takes full power. During his reign, the absolutism of the *ancien régime* reaches its peak. At home the arts flourish under his patronage. Abroad he establishes French hegemony over much of Western Europe in a series of victorious military campaigns, pushing France's borders north into Flanders and east to the Rhine. However, from 1700, as Europe unites in resistance, his position begins to be undermined.

1664 French East India Company founded and begins to set up trading colonies on the east coast of India.

1685 Revocation of the Edict of Nantes sends many Huguenots into exile in England and Germany.

1701–13 War of the Spanish Succession breaks out when Louis tries to place his grandson Philip on the throne of France. Philip is eventually recognized as Bourbon king of Spain, but renounces any future claim to the throne of France.

1715 Death of Louis XIV. His successor, Louis XV (1715–74), lacks interest in government and politics and is less successful in campaigns abroad and in countering growing opposition at home.

1740 The War of the Austrian Succession follows the death of the last male Habsburg emperor, Charles VI. France and Prussia unsuccessfully support the claim of the Elector of Bavaria to the Habsburg throne against that of Charles's daughter Maria Theresa, whose claim is upheld at the Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle (1748).

1756–63 The Seven Years War continues disputes left unresolved by the Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle as Britain and France seek to win maritime and colonial supremacy in North America, the West Indies, and India. As a result of British success in the war, France is obliged to cede almost all of its possessions in North America, the West Indies, and India to Britain, and lands west of the Mississippi to Spain, and is left with little of its large American empire remaining.

1766 France annexes Duchy of Lorraine, consolidating its eastern border on the Rhine.

1776–83 Expensive support for the Americans in their Revolution helps undermine the *ancien régime*.

1789 For the first time since 1614, Louis XVI (1774–92) summons the advisory Estates-General in an attempt to secure revenue for the bankrupt government. As the nobles and clergy (the first and second estates) lose control to the "third estate" (the commoners), a national

assembly is formed by the third estate and demands reform of the monarchy. Louis XVI's indecisive response sparks the storming of the Bastille on July 14. The National Assembly issues the "Declaration of the Rights of Man." Further hesitation on Louis XVI's part prompts the women of Paris to march to Versailles in October to demand bread; they take the royal family to Paris as hostages.

1790 A new constitution

is proclaimed, but in 1791 the king and his family attempt to flee the country in disguise. However, they are brought back as prisoners and Louis is forced to accept the new constitution.

1792 Royalist émigrés begin to muster support abroad as Austria and Prussia declare war on behalf of the king. Britain, Spain, and Holland declare war in 1793. The Paris mob storms the royal palace of the Tuileries. The Paris Commune led by Georges Danton seizes power and a national convention replaces the national assembly and abolishes the monarchy.

1793 Louis XVI is tried, convicted, and executed. Control of the country passes from the moderate Girondins to the extremist Jacobins, led by Maximilien François Robespierre as the "Reign of Terror" begins with a series of mass executions.

1794 Robespierre's Committee of Public Safety is overthrown in a coup and Robespierre is executed. A new constitution in 1795 establishes the more moderate Directory which, however, becomes increasingly corrupt.

1799 Napoleon Bonaparte, a successful general from Corsica, overthrows the Directory and in a coup assumes dictatorial powers as First Consul.

1804 At his coronation in Paris, Napoleon takes the crown from the pope and proclaims himself Emperor of the French. At home he introduces many reforms, including the legal "Code Napoléon"; abroad he defeats the Austrians and Russians at Austerlitz in 1805 and the Prussians at Jena in 1806.

1812 Napoleon's invasion of Russia leads to defeat at the hands of the Russian winter and to the Austro-Prussian capture of Paris in 1814. He is deposed and sent into exile on Elba. The Bourbon monarchy is reinstalled, with Louis XVIII, younger brother of Louis XVII, as king.

1815 Napoleon returns from exile for a final "hundred days" that end in defeat by British and Prussian forces at the Battle of Waterloo. Louis XVIII returns again.

Paris Commune

This medal was awarded to a supporter of the short-lived Paris Commune of 1871, formed in the period of turmoil following the Franco-Prussian war.

1830 Louis XVIII's brother

Charles X, who ascended the throne in 1824, is forced to abdicate in the "July Revolution" and Louis-Philippe I of Orléans is installed as the "citizen king."

1830 The capture of Algiers

marks the beginning of France's second colonial empire, in North Africa.

1848 At a time of food shortages, Louis Philippe is toppled by popular riots in a revolution and a Second Republic is proclaimed. Charles-Louis Napoleon, nephew of Napoleon Bonaparte, is elected president with more than 70 percent of the total vote.

1851 Napoleon seizes power in a coup d'état with the support of monarchists and the army.

1852 Charles-Louis Napoleon takes the title Emperor Napoleon III. He proclaims a Second Empire based on plebiscitary autocracy and becomes involved in wars with Russia in the Crimea in 1854–56 and with Austria in 1859, gaining Savoy and Nice from Piedmont in 1860.

1863 Napoleon III supports an ill-fated venture to install a puppet emperor in Mexico. French prestige suffers when Maximilian I is executed in 1867.

1870 Napoleon III declares war on Prussia to gain diplomatic dominance in Europe. French armies are quickly defeated at Metz and Sedan, where Napoleon is captured. The Third Republic is proclaimed and continues resistance until Prussian forces enter Paris in January 1871. France is obliged to cede Alsace and Lorraine to Germany.

Napoleon III

Nephew of Napoleon Bonaparte, Charles-Louis Napoleon twice tried to overthrow Louis-Philippe but was elected president of France in 1848, seized power in 1851, and became emperor the following year.

